MARKETING GUIDE

Why Your Marketing Photos *Are Missing the Mark*

You don't need to be a photographer to judge a great photo. You need the right questions.

PAUL PACEY



Before a parent reads a word, *your imagery has already spoken.*

Your school only gets one first impression. Long before prospective parents read about your curriculum or values, your imagery has already created an instant emotional connection, or a subtle reason to move on. Knowing which is easier than you think.

You don't need to be a photographer to judge a photograph objectively.
You need four simple questions.

FOUR SIMPLE QUESTIONS

01	Does it look good?	AESTHETIC
02	Does it feel good?	EMOTION
03	Does it tell a story?	NARRATIVE
04	*Is it believable?*	AUTHENTICITY

01

Does it look good?

The foundation, not the finish. A technically solid image isn't enough on its own, but every other layer is built on it. It's also where a surprising number of school images already fall short.

- **Exposure:** Is it too dark or too light? Can you clearly see the faces?
- **Composition:** Does it feel balanced? Is anything awkwardly cut off? Is there more in the frame than it needs?
- **Focus:** Is it obvious what the image is about? Is that subject sharp when you zoom in?
- **Light:** Is the light flattering to faces, or is it either lifeless and flat or too harsh with heavy shadows?
- **Color:** Do skin tones look natural and healthy?


01 Does it look good?
02 Does it feel good?
03 Does it tell a story?
04 *Is it believable?*

02

Does it feel good?

An emotionally charged photo—even one with technical flaws—will always beat a technically perfect image that feels empty. Capturing genuine emotion is the hardest part of visual storytelling, but when combined with true authenticity, it becomes the single most powerful driver of trust and connection.

- **Feeling:** Does it express a positive emotion or state of mind, such as joy, curiosity, focus, pride or belonging?
- **Expressions:** Are they genuine, or performed for the camera?
- **Connection:** Is there a bond between people, or between a student and their work?
- **Relatability:** Could a parent picture their own child in this moment?
- **Impact:** Does it make *you* feel something?


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03

Does it tell a story?

Narrative is the context behind your message: who's there, what's happening, and why it matters.

- **Moment:** Is there a defining moment that tells a bigger story?
- **Clarity:** Is it understood at a glance, or does it need explaining?

EXCEPTION TO THE RULE

Sometimes, less is more. For hero imagery—like poster or billboard shots—a busy narrative can actually distract. A clean, minimal focus on a single student or teacher creates a stronger visual impact and leaves room for headline copy and graphics to deliver the message.

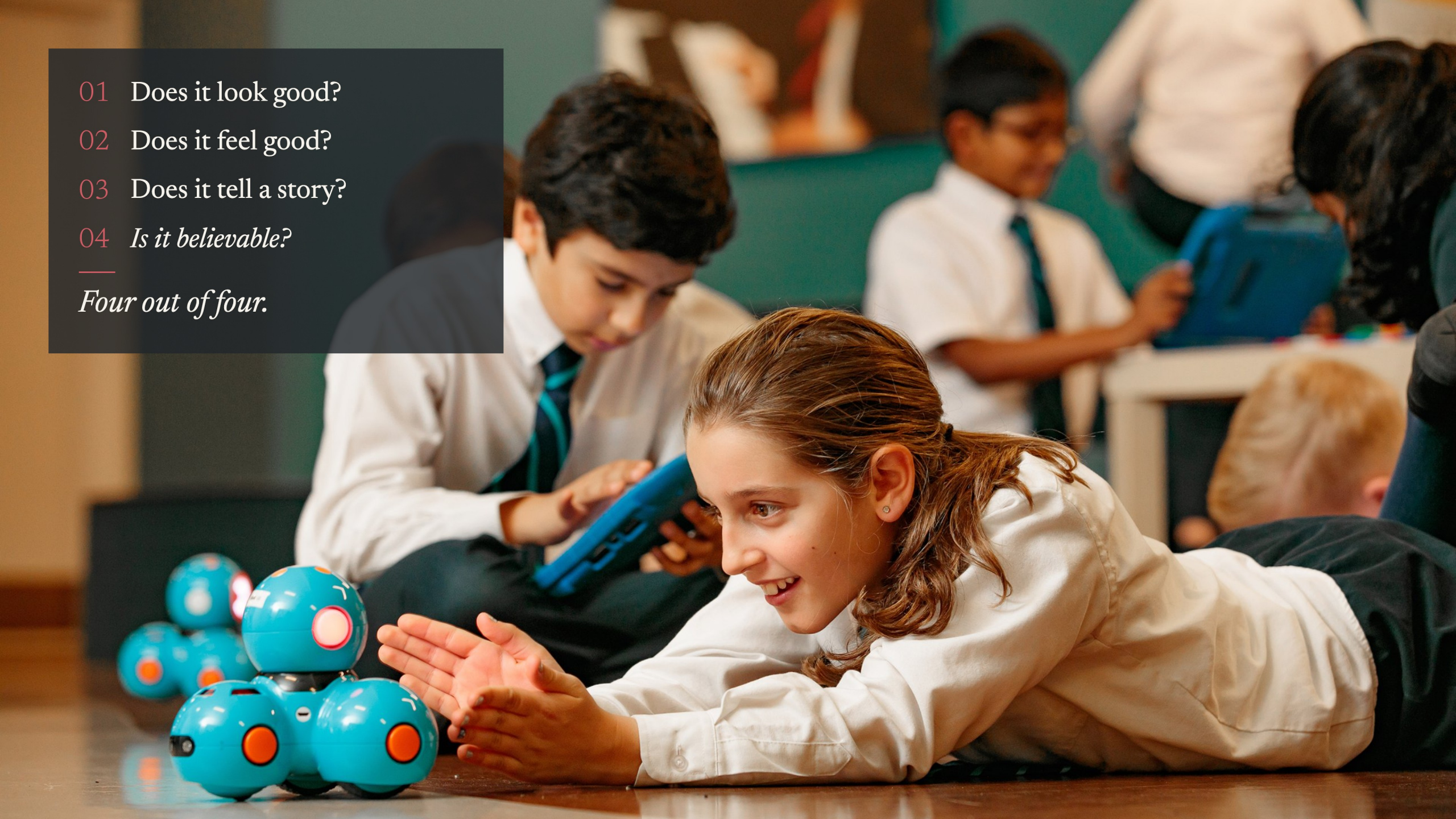

01 Does it look good?
02 Does it feel good?
03 Does it tell a story?
04 *Is it believable?*

04

Is it believable?

An image can look good, feel good, tell a story—and still fail completely if it isn't believable. Instead of building trust, a clearly manufactured image signals that the reality of your school doesn't match the marketing.

- **Unscripted:** Does the moment look and feel natural, or does everything look a little *too* rigid or orchestrated?
- **Engagement:** Are people engaged with each other or their work, rather than posing for the camera?
- **Spontaneous:** **BONUS** Is there an unmistakable sense of an unplanned moment or interaction?



01 Does it look good?

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Four out of four.

Now, what's the one thing *these images have in common?*








Spontaneity.

The hallmark of authenticity.



SPONTANEITY

Not every image needs a big reaction *to be believable.*

In the right balance, a healthy dose of honest introspection or quiet focus may be more befitting.



SPONTANEITY

But few images resonate on an emotional level more than *an authentic flash of unscripted joy.*

Where a student's genuine happiness bridges the gap between your school and a parent's imagination.



REMEMBER

While you can't schedule spontaneity, *you can make space for it.*

A good plan should always make room for the moments you can't plan for.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

Ready?
Let's put it *to the test!*

Six images, each missing one piece. Ask the four questions and see if you can spot which.



SPOT THE GAP · 1 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 2 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 3 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

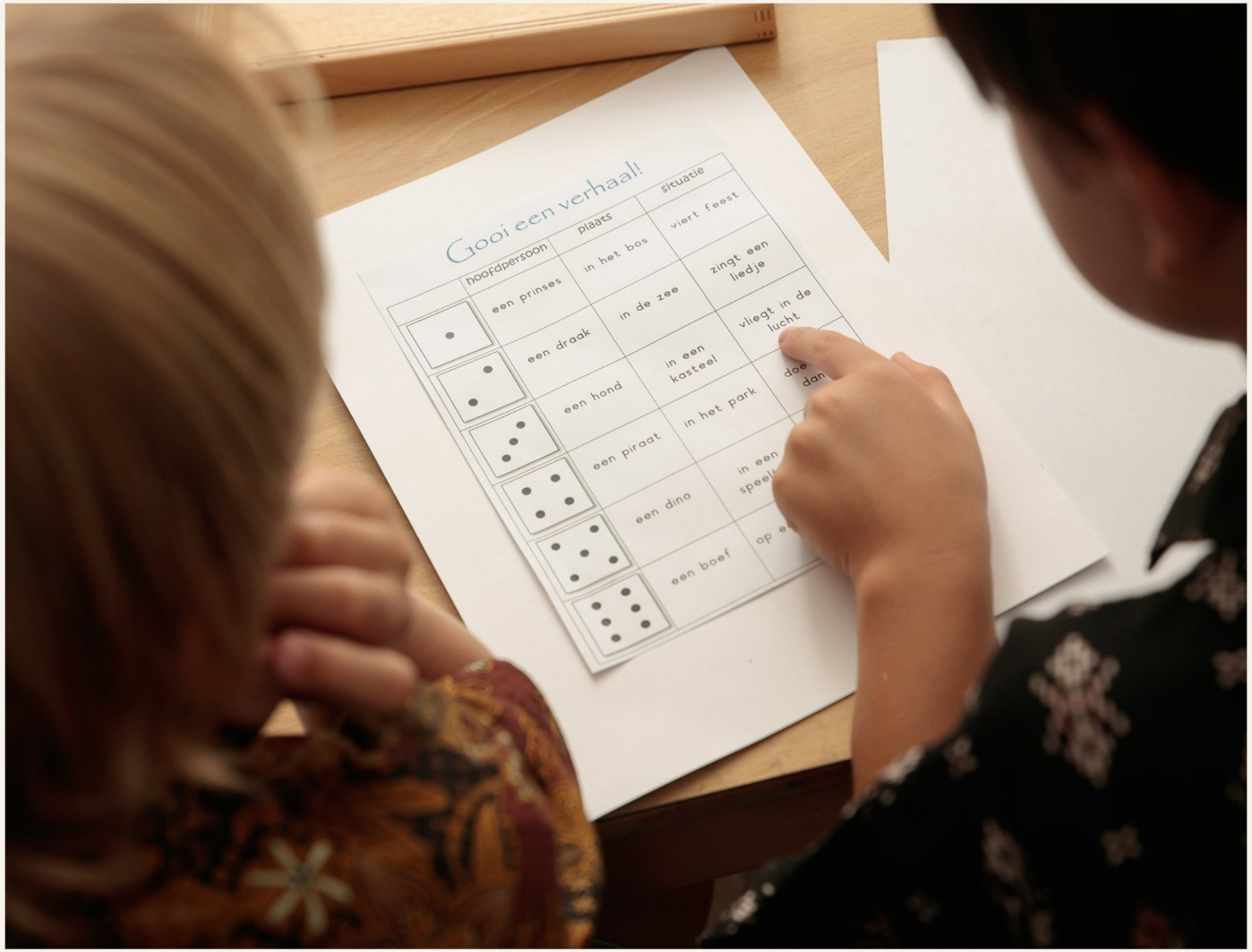
01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 4 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 5 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 6 OF 6

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

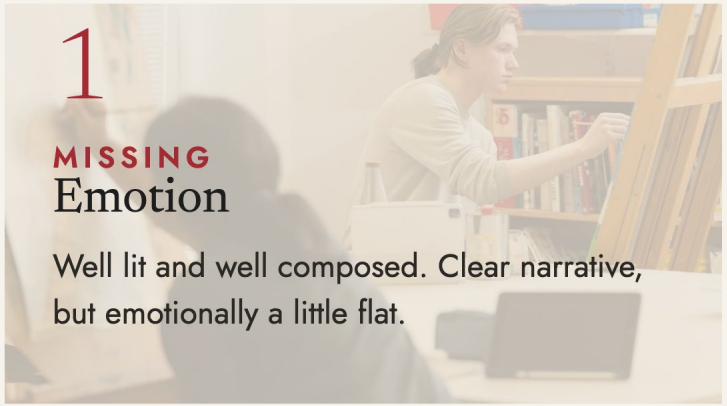
03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.

SPOT THE GAPS · ANSWERS

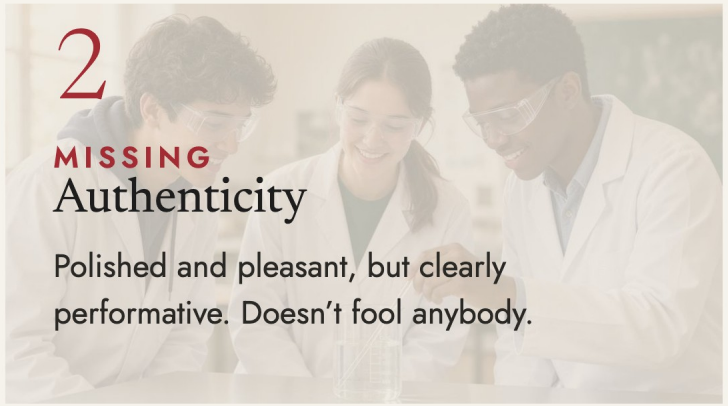
How did *you do?*



1

MISSING
Emotion

Well lit and well composed. Clear narrative, but emotionally a little flat.



2

MISSING
Authenticity

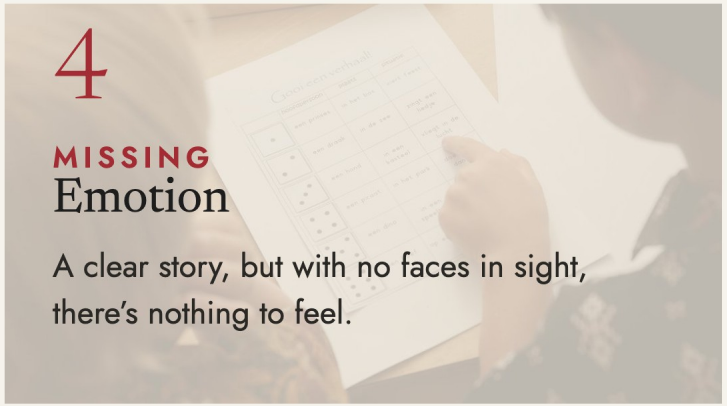
Polished and pleasant, but clearly performative. Doesn't fool anybody.



3

MISSING
Aesthetic

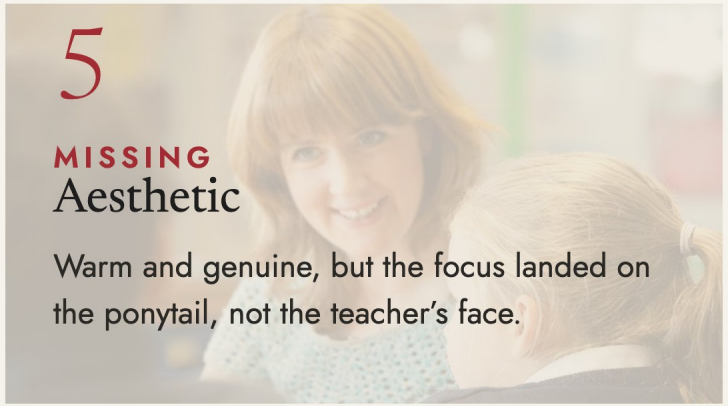
Right moment, wrong light: dull skin tones and faces lost in shadow.



4

MISSING
Emotion

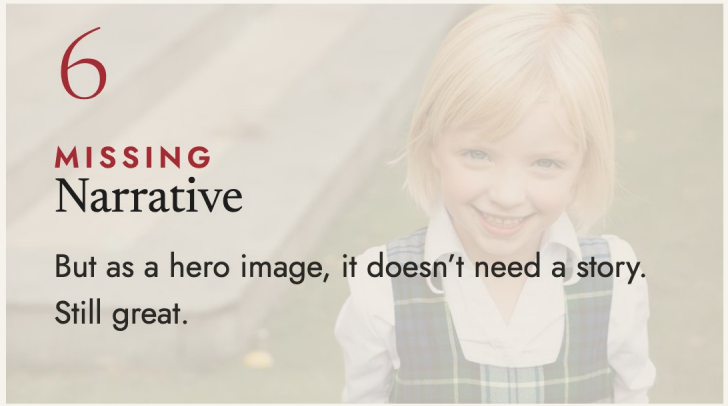
A clear story, but with no faces in sight, there's nothing to feel.



5

MISSING
Aesthetic

Warm and genuine, but the focus landed on the ponytail, not the teacher's face.



6

MISSING
Narrative

But as a hero image, it doesn't need a story. Still great.

All images by Paul Pacey, except round 2 (AI-generated).

THE TAKEAWAY

Great imagery isn’t left *to chance.*

Great school marketing photography comes from creating the right environment, knowing what to look for, and holding your visuals to the highest standards—one image at a time.

Now, how do your own images *stack up?*

If the honest answer is “not quite,” let’s *talk* and close the gap.

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